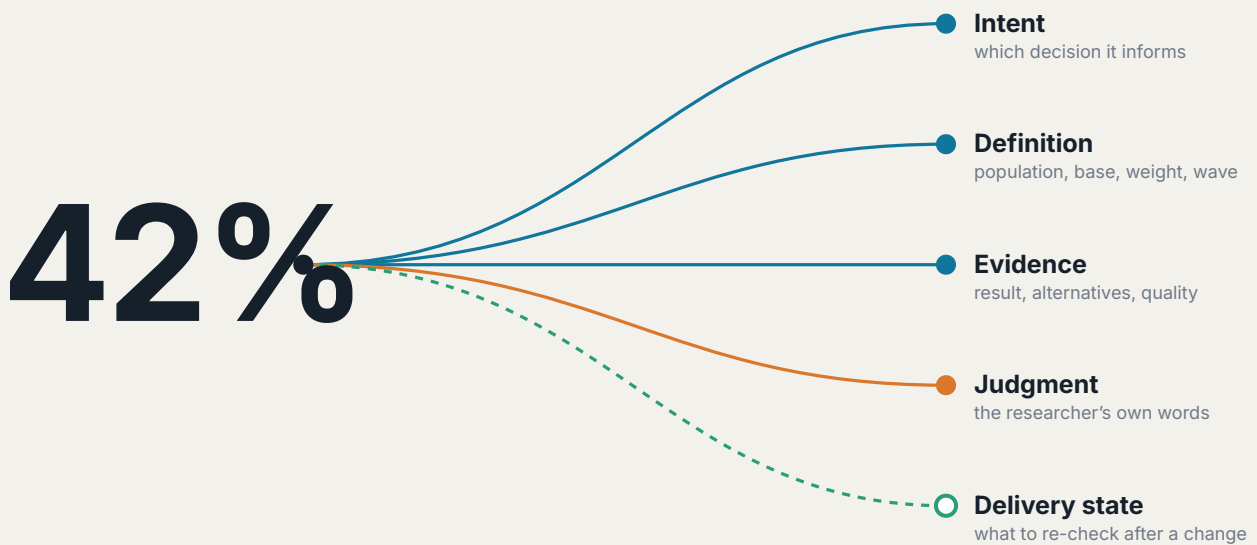


Holding the *number*

How quantitative researchers work in 2026, what they say about evidence and AI, and where Velocity fits.



DATE

26 September 2026

PREPARED FOR

Velocity product owner

STATUS

Desk research and product inference;
not user research

What this report covers

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How to read the evidence

Survey statistics about researchers come from very different samples. Every claim in this report carries one of five labels so a reader can weigh it without re-reading the sources.

LABEL	WHAT IT MEANS	EXAMPLE
MEASURED	An experiment, audit, or methodological study that observed an outcome directly.	Pew's screening experiment on 11,114 respondents
INDUSTRY SURVEY	A professional-body or independent survey of researchers. Self-reported attitudes and practice, usually non-probability.	MRII, GRIT, MRS/AURA
VENDOR SAMPLE	A survey run by a software company, often self-selected. Directional; it also shows what the vendor wants to sell.	Displayr quiz, Harris/QuestDIY, Qualtrics
PRACTITIONER VOICE	A named or described researcher speaking for themselves — a quote, talk, interview, or practice guide. Illustrative, not representative.	IIEX speakers, study participants, client-side leads
INFERENCE	Our reading of the evidence for Velocity. A hypothesis to test, not a finding.	Proposed position; segment hypothesis

The hard part is not the first answer. It is keeping the answer true.

Researchers have adopted AI almost universally, but they have not handed it the responsibility for a number. The durable pain is being able to say what a figure means, why it changed, and whether the conclusion still stands — as a study moves between people, tools, and revisions.

1 Responsibility, not job title, is the useful boundary.

Quant and qual specialists still exist, but most brand-side researchers' work spans several methods and several collaborators. Design for the research lead, the data/operations specialist, and the client-side insight lead around each finding. **INDUSTRY SURVEY** **INFERENCE**

2 Agencies are not disappearing.

MRS puts UK supply-side research, insight, and analytics turnover at about £9.5bn with 75,000+ workers; ESOMAR sizes the global insights industry at about \$153bn. Clients still buy judgment, execution, and accountability. **INDUSTRY SURVEY**

3 Use is near-universal; embedding and trust are not.

95–98% of researchers in two vendor samples use AI, yet only about one in ten say it is embedded across their workflow, 90% are not fully confident in its accuracy, and 67% double-check every output.

VENDOR SAMPLE **INDUSTRY SURVEY**

4 Researchers describe their stance as authorship.

Across conferences and studies the same idea recurs: AI should “inform judgment,” not replace it, and researchers should remain “the authors and not the editors” of their insight. **PRACTITIONER VOICE**

5 Cleaning decisions change answers.

In Pew's August 2026 experiment, three reasonable screening methods kept between 36% and 82% of respondents and moved one subgroup estimate from an 8-point to a 19-point lead. There is no neutral “clean” button. **MEASURED**

6 Analytical memory is fragile even where it is most valued.

An audit of 699 published survey-based results reproduced only about half numerically and 18% exactly; 23% failed on incomplete materials. Commercial projects are unlikely to be better documented.

MEASURED **INFERENCE**

7 Traceability is already a competitor claim.

Displayr says every number traces to tables, tests, weights, variables, and source; quantilope says quinn now runs the full lifecycle. Velocity's difference must be observable in a difficult task — above all, a late change. **VENDOR SAMPLE** **INFERENCE**

THE QUESTION TO TEST NEXT

Can one researcher carry a defensible answer through a change — a new population, a corrected weight, a suspect batch, a new wave — with less reconstruction and less risk than they can today?

The quant–qual split still exists. It is just not where the work divides.

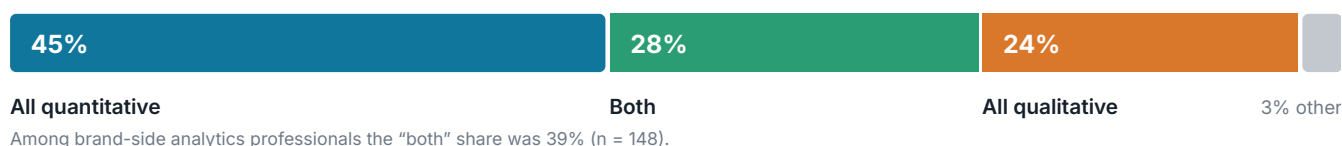
Specialist roles persist, especially in large agencies. But a finding passes through several hands, and in smaller teams one person holds several of them.

Specialists are real. MRS maintains separate career pathways, and Ipsos advertises roles explicitly for quantitative research, survey scripting, and data processing. A current Ipsos client-service role spans questionnaire checks, sample monitoring, validation, Excel/SPSS preparation, and client deliverables; a separate processing role scripts surveys and produces tables.²⁷ **PRACTITIONER VOICE**

But researchers’ projects mix methods. In Greenbook’s 2026 GRIT sample of brand-side researchers, fewer than half said all their projects were quantitative, and more than a quarter said their projects involved both.¹⁰ This describes the *allocation of their projects*, not the make-up of the industry.

Brand-side researchers’ project mix

Share of respondents describing their projects as... · GRIT 2026, brand-side researchers, n = 170



Source: Greenbook GRIT 2026 Insights Practice Report, as recorded in Velocity’s research note of 26 September 2026. **INDUSTRY SURVEY**
North-America-heavy, non-probability; the full GRIT sample is 735.

Responsibilities blur while organisations don’t converge. GRIT 2026 describes an industry “splitting into two operating models”: analytics professionals are expanding on every tracked dimension, while traditional research functions face budget pressure and a narrowing method portfolio.¹⁰ Its commentary reports blurred responsibilities without evidence that insights and analytics teams are merging. “Everyone is now a mixed-methods researcher” would overstate the evidence.

Design for three collaborators around each finding

PERSON	THE QUESTION THEY MUST ANSWER	WHAT THEY NEED TO SEE
Research lead	Does this answer the brief, and can I defend the interpretation to the client?	Intent, claim, caveats, alternatives considered
Data / operations specialist	Which source fields, cleaning decisions, weights, bases, and tests produced it?	Definitions, transformations, exclusions, universes
Client-side insight lead	Can I use it in a decision, explain its limits, and revisit it later?	Portable answer, limits, what changed since

The same person may occupy several rows. Velocity’s job is to preserve the handoff between them. **INFERENCE**

Clients still buy judgment and accountability, not only software.

£9.5bn

UK research, insight & analytics **supply-side** turnover (MRS)

Sources 21–23. **INDUSTRY SURVEY**

75,000+

workers in more than 4,000 UK enterprises (MRS)

\$153bn

global insights industry, 2024 (ESOMAR Global Market Research 2025)

DO NOT ADD THESE FIGURES TOGETHER

MRS's £9.5bn is **supply-side turnover**. Its separate £18.7bn “Business of Evidence” figure uses a broader lens covering analytics, data, and evidence functions across the economy.²² They measure different things. Likewise ESOMAR's categories are industry-wide, not Velocity's serviceable market.

Where the \$153bn sits

ESOMAR estimate of the 2024 global insights industry, US\$ billions



Market research still contains substantial full-service and fieldwork activity; software grew faster in 2024.

Sources: ESOMAR via Research World (total); category split as reported in the originating memo and not re-checked against the full ESOMAR report in this pass.²³

A segment hypothesis, not a winning market

GRIT's 2026 supplier analysis describes a particularly strong operating profile among service firms with 101–500 staff, infrastructure constraints for small specialists, and a managed transition for the largest firms. That analysis mixes survey results with advisers' interpretation, so it should shape a hypothesis rather than settle one. Meanwhile ESOMAR's buyer research places in-house execution at around half of projects for several team structures, with wide variation by sector (30% in-house in FMCG, 23% in pharmaceuticals).^{10,28} The in-house/agency line is a handoff pattern, not a binary.

PRIMARY HYPOTHESIS

A **small or mid-sized agency** running recurring quantitative studies or trackers, with several people touching each project and clients expecting editable PowerPoint and Excel. Enough repeat work that mistakes and rework are expensive; not enough engineering to build a connected workflow. **INFERENCE**

SECONDARY HYPOTHESIS

The **client-side team** that receives work from several agencies and must interrogate, reuse, and defend it internally. MRS/AURA's ClientSight 2025 found growing impact and influence were both top priorities and top challenges for these professionals.²⁹

INDUSTRY SURVEY

Eight moments where meaning can quietly change.

Triangulated from current job descriptions, platform documentation, and disclosure standards. It is a workflow model to validate, not a measured time-use study.

MOMENT	THE RESEARCHER'S REAL TASK	FREQUENT FAILURE OR COST
01 Brief & proposal	Turn a business decision into a population, measures, method, timeline, and deliverable.	A vague question survives until reporting; unpromising pitches consume scarce capacity.
02 Questionnaire & programming	Define routing, response options, quotas, and what each measure will mean.	The programmed instrument diverges from the approved questionnaire.
03 Fieldwork	Monitor sample, quotas, incidence, and quality.	Fraud, poor answers, composition shifts, and late changes — including undisclosed top-up sample.
04 Preparation	Reconcile files, labels, missing codes, multiple responses, exclusions, and weights.	A plausible-looking dataset carries a wrong denominator or a silent recode.
05 Exploration	Work through tables, segments, waves, tests, and open ends.	Many interesting cuts, small bases, uncertain relevance, lost reasoning.
06 Interpretation	Decide which findings matter, test alternatives, write caveats.	The attractive result beats the robust one; prose outlives changed evidence.
07 Delivery	Check tables, build slides and workbooks, answer client questions.	Repeated copying, inconsistent figures, hard-to-reconstruct numbers.
08 Next wave	Reuse definitions and outputs with a changed questionnaire or sample.	A refreshed chart appears comparable when the measure is not.

The small details are part of the result. AAPOR's Transparency Initiative requires population, full question wording and answer options, sample construction, mode, weighting, and more to be disclosed with findings, and further details within 30 days of a request.²⁴ Its June 2026 code extends this to processing, quality checks, exclusions, and AI use. In survey work, source-to-claim traceability is a professional obligation before it is a product feature.

Where the quality work actually lands. In the Global Data Quality benchmark led by the Insights Association, sample providers reported removing 0.8% of respondents in-survey for fraud and quality reasons; research agencies reported 3.3%.¹⁹ **INDUSTRY SURVEY** The gap suggests that consequential quality judgments are made downstream, by the agency, after data arrives — exactly the moment Velocity's preparation microscope targets. **INFERENCE**

"Inform judgment. Do not replace it."

What researchers say when they describe their own relationship to evidence and to AI. These are illustrative voices, not a representative sample — but they are strikingly consistent.

"We use it to inform judgment. We do not use it to replace judgment."

Speaker at IIEX Europe 2026, reported by Greenbook, July 2026¹¹

The same coverage urges researchers to stay accountable for their work and to "remain the authors and not the editors" of their own insight.

"No matter what question you ask, the platform always gives you an answer, even when it's not directly related."

Participant P6, think-aloud study of 15 researchers, FAccT 2026¹³

The authors found that AI's confident tone "misrepresents epistemic uncertainty," making it harder for the accountable researcher to know what to scrutinise.

"Students would never know the applicability of information."

Participant, same study, on junior researchers¹³

Concern that AI can hide gaps in understanding rather than reveal them — a real risk where junior executives do first-pass analysis.

"A syntax file with no comments still runs; it just stops being useful to anyone — including the researcher who wrote it, six months later."

CASRAI practice guide on reproducible SPSS analysis¹⁷

"...some of it no doubt misplaced..."

Client-side insight leader, Research Live Industry Report 2026¹⁴

On the trust colleagues now place in what AI produces. Leaders from Virgin Media O2, the BBC, Sage and Vue describe "cutting through the noise with credibility" as their challenge.

"It's exciting to be at the start of the AI journey and to be able to take ownership of how it can add value..."

Client-side insight professional, Research Live Industry Report 2025¹⁵

Note the word *ownership*: enthusiasm framed as control.

"A trend is only real if every wave measured it the same way."

Tracker practice guide, PulseAI Research¹⁸

It warns that sample quietly topped up from a second supplier when a quota underfills causes more unexplained trend breaks than any other single factor, and asks tools to treat a wave as a first-class object with an audit trail.

"...to save time while keeping control."

Most-chosen goal among 203 researchers, Displayr, March 2026⁴

35% chose this, ahead of end-to-end automation at 32%.

WHAT THE VOICES ADD UP TO

Researchers welcome speed but define their professional value as **authorship and accountability**. Their anxieties are specific: confident output that hides uncertainty, reasoning that cannot be recovered later, comparisons that silently stop being comparable, and juniors who cannot tell when something is wrong. A product that makes these visible serves the researcher's identity rather than threatening it.

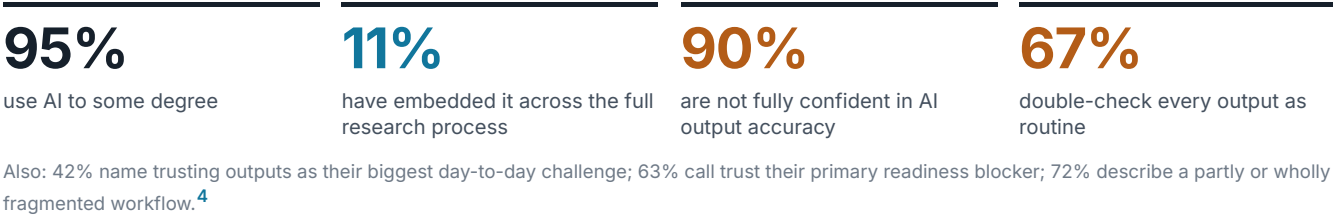
INFERENCE

Quotations were captured from search-indexed excerpts of the named sources because direct page access was blocked in this research environment. Check wording against the originals before external use. Forum voices (Reddit, Hacker News, LinkedIn) could not be accessed and remain a gap.

Researchers use AI every day and check almost everything it produces.

Six surveys from 2025–26 tell a consistent story from different angles. Their samples differ sharply, so read each on its own terms.

Displayr AI Readiness Quiz · March 2026 · n = 203 self-selected researchers VENDOR SAMPLE



Harris Poll / QuestDIY · August 2025 · n = 219 US researchers VENDOR SAMPLE

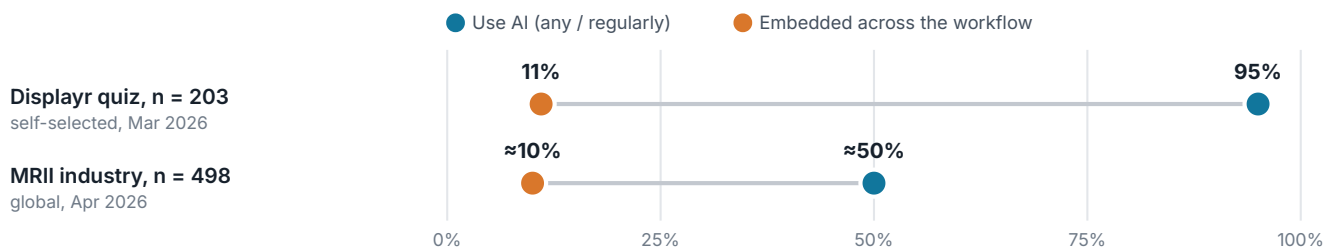


The wider picture

SOURCE	SAMPLE	WHAT IT ADDS	TYPE
MRII State of the Industry 2026	498 professionals, global, Apr 2026	About half use AI regularly, but only 1 in 10 say it is fully embedded in standard workflows. 63% worry about AI-driven job loss; 57% are highly satisfied with their jobs. ⁷	SURVEY
MRII AI in Focus 2025	426 researchers, global, Feb 2025	62% report AI use by themselves or their team (up 23 points); 77% favourable. Time saving is the dominant perceived benefit, well ahead of better insight. ⁶	SURVEY
MRII job satisfaction 2025	MRII panel	Satisfaction fell to 59% from 65% in 2024; only 35% satisfied with advancement. Top training need: AI/ML (55%). ⁸	SURVEY
GRIT Insights Practice 2026	735 industry respondents	A governance gap : teams driving AI adoption are often least confident that AI risks are managed. Agentic AI is already embedded in analysing data, updating reports, and preparing data. ¹⁰	SURVEY
Qualtrics Market Research Trends 2026	3,000+ researchers, global	Only 13% identify as “traditional” non-users; 15% actively use AI agents; 78% <i>expect</i> agents to run over half of projects end-to-end within three years — an expectation, not an observation. ⁹	VENDOR

The use–embedding gap

Share of researchers who use AI vs. share who say it is embedded across their workflow · two independent 2026 samples



Different samples and question wording; compare the gap within each row, not values across rows.

Sources: Displayr ("use AI to some degree"; "embedded across the full research process")⁴; MRIL 2026 ("about half ... regularly"; "1 in 10 ... fully embedded in standard workflows").⁷

READING ACROSS THE SURVEYS

The gap between **use** (roughly 50–98%) and **embedding** (roughly 10%) is the most consistent pattern across sources, and the most relevant to Velocity. Researchers have added AI to steps; they have not rebuilt the workflow around it, because they cannot yet verify it cheaply. Verification cost, not capability, is the bottleneck — which is precisely where a product built around inspectable evidence could earn its place. **INFERENCE**

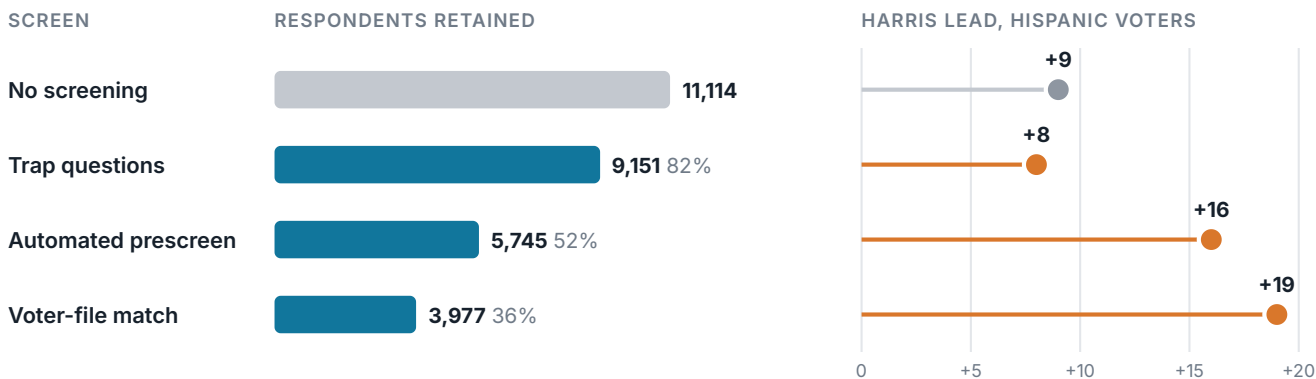
Pressure predates AI. An MRS qualitative study of supply-side talent (2022) described long hours, manual work, and researchers stretching to protect client quality; this pass could not re-locate it, so treat it as evidence of longstanding dynamics, not a measured 2026 rate. A product that simply lets agencies take on more projects may intensify that strain. The desirable experience is less reconstruction and checking, and more time to reason and speak confidently to a client.

Three reasonable cleaning rules. Three different answers.

Pew Research Center's August 2026 study screened one opt-in survey three ways. Removing suspect respondents generally lowered error, but no method reliably solved the problem — and the choice of method moved results.

Same 11,114 respondents, four analysis populations

Left: respondents retained by each screen. Right: Harris's lead among Hispanic voters in the resulting sample, percentage points.



Voter-file matching slightly **increased** overall error, mostly by removing good respondents who simply declined to give a name or address.

Source: Pew Research Center, "No Easy Fix for Bogus Respondents in Online Opt-In Polls," 27 Aug 2026; online opt-in survey of 11,114 US adults, 14–19 Nov 2024, sample via CloudResearch from Cint's Lucid marketplace.^{1,2} **MEASURED**

Why it matters for Velocity

Pew also found bogus respondents disproportionately claim to be young or Hispanic, producing subgroup errors nearly twice the general-population error in an earlier benchmark.¹ A quality rule is therefore a **substantive analytical choice** that changes who a percentage describes. It deserves the same inspection and provenance as a weight.

This directly supports PR #80's **inspect a flag** → **see its effect** → **then decide** pattern, and argues against any "one-click clean." **INFERENCE**

The tracker version of the same problem

Tracker guidance converges on one rule: keep core wording, translations, sample sources, and composition identical wave to wave, record every deliberate change, and annotate charts when something did change.¹⁸ **PRACTITIONER VOICE**

Quirks contributors describe fraud from bad actors, bots, and AI imitation as an existential threat, compounded by long, repetitive surveys that degrade even honest answers.²⁰ The study was discussed widely, including on Columbia's statistics blog.³

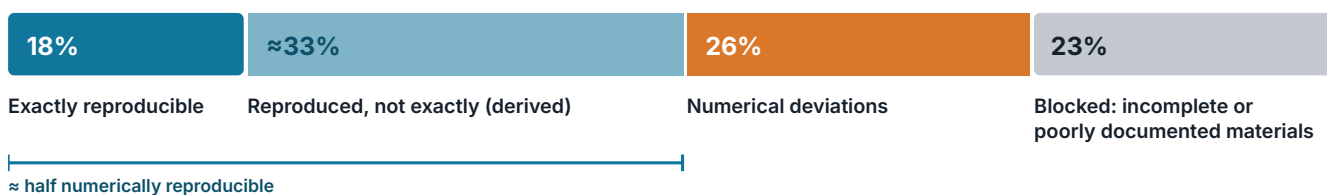
Even with the code in hand, only half the results came back.

The most direct evidence on analytical memory comes from academic survey research, where documentation norms are strongest. That makes it a conservative benchmark for commercial work.

Krähmer, Schächtele and Auspurg audited more than 1,000 articles built on the European Social Survey (2015–2020). Only about 35% of authors shared code. For 100 articles with code available, they attempted to reproduce 699 published results from raw data.¹⁶ **MEASURED**

Outcome of attempting to reproduce 699 published survey results

Articles where analysis code was shared · share of results



Source: Krähmer, Schächtele & Auspurg, Royal Society Open Science, 2026. The ~33% middle segment is derived as the remainder of the reported “around half” reproducible after the 18% exact; treat it as approximate.¹⁶

Why this is relevant to agencies. Commercial projects rarely publish code, frequently change hands, and must answer client questions weeks after delivery. If a disciplined academic workflow loses a quarter of its results to missing materials, the agency equivalent — “which base was that, and who applied the exclusion?” — is plausibly worse. This is inference; no equivalent audit of commercial research was found. **INFERENCE**

IMPLICATION

A durable record of **definition, transformation, and judgment** attached to each claim is not a nice-to-have audit feature. It is the thing most likely to be missing when a client disputes a number or a new wave arrives. The unit Velocity should preserve is not the table or the chart; it is the answer and its reasons.

“Easy crosstabs” and “traceable AI” are both taken.

Researchers cross boundaries between collection platforms, processing teams or files, analysis tools, and presentation software. The examples below establish capabilities, not market share.

LAYER	EXAMPLES AND WHAT THEY ALREADY DO	IMPLICATION FOR VELOCITY
Collection & fieldwork	Qualtrics and Forsta cover survey data, weighting, crosstabs, and field reporting; specialist teams handle scripting, checks, tabulation, coding. Qualtrics launched synthetic panels at X4 2026. ⁹	Do not assume Velocity must own survey authoring or sample supply.
Processing & analysis	Excel, SPSS/Dimensions, Q/Displayr, Forsta, Crunch, and scripted R/Python. Crunch addresses preparation and sharing; Displayr connects cleaning, tables, tests, and reporting. ²⁷	Crosstabs alone is an exposed position.
Integrated AI research	Displayr: every number “traced back to the tables, tests, weights, variables, and source”; its agent detects filters and weights automatically. ²⁵ quantilope: quinn now runs the “full end-to-end research lifecycle” (Feb 2026), under a “Human-Led, AI-Powered” banner. ²⁶ Zappi: standardised on-demand studies.	Neither end-to-end AI nor provenance is unique. Velocity must show its difference in a hard task.
Qual & mixed methods	Platforms combine structured responses with AI-moderated interviews and source-linked qualitative analysis.	Make room for qualitative context without building a qual platform.
Client delivery	Native PowerPoint, Excel, PDFs, dashboards; vendors already automate refreshes and editable exports. Displayr notes automatic updates can overwrite edits, hence explicit reruns.	The value is whether an exported assertion stays accurate, intelligible, and easy to revise.

WHERE THE COMPETITIVE BAR ACTUALLY IS

Every competitor can demonstrate a clean first answer on a well-behaved file. Few demonstrations show what happens to **edited prose, approved caveats, and exported slides** when the population, weight, exclusion, or wave changes. That late-change path is where Velocity’s claim should be tested — and against a capable baseline such as Displayr/Q or the researcher’s own stack, not a strawman.

INFERENCE

Findings researchers can explain, challenge, revise, and stand behind.

Broader than “analysis software,” narrower and more credible than “an AI researcher.” The unit of value is a **defensible answer to a research question**.

1 Intent The client question and the decision it informs.	2 Definition Population, eligibility, numerator, denominator, missing policy, weighting, comparable waves.	3 Evidence Computed result, bases, relevant alternatives, quality concerns, source references.	4 Judgment The researcher’s interpretation, caveat, and review decision — in their words.	5 Delivery state Which slides, workbooks, or shared answers depend on it; what is due for review after a change.
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This is substantially aligned with PR #80’s exploration and the reviewed handoff in PRs #75 and #79. The added emphasis is **the late change**. A researcher discovers the product’s value when a client changes the target population, a weight is corrected, a suspect batch is investigated, or wave five contains a new response code: can they see the affected claims, keep their own reasoning, and repair the deliverable without starting over?

Which prototypes matter most

PROTOTYPE	RESEARCHER JOB IT SERVES	PRIORITY
Preparation microscope + population lens	Make an error visible at the moment it can be corrected; state who a percentage describes. Directly answers the Pew finding that cleaning choices move estimates.	LEAD
Measure identity + wave rehearsal	Potentially the strongest durable value for trackers: a refreshed number without a stable definition is dangerous. Include a deliberately incompatible wave — a product that confidently maps it should fail.	LEAD
Reviewed narrative & export (PRs #75/#79)	Closes the loop: preserve the researcher’s wording while marking precisely which claims need another look after evidence changes.	LEAD
Assumption lab	Valuable when a consequential claim is sensitive to a justified choice. Keep it bounded so it does not become a machine for searching out favourable results.	BOUNDED
Question desk vs notebook	Competing main-workspace ideas. Test both on the same interrupted, revised project; choose by how readily a researcher resumes and explains the work.	COMPARE
Signal inbox	Directs attention after a revised file or wave; “interesting” rankings may miss client context, so expose selection criteria.	LATER

NO MOAT CLAIMED

The prototypes use synthetic fixtures and interaction checks; there is no researcher usability result or measured correction burden, and the research-evaluation PRs are explicit about missing human ratings. The defensible claim today is a **promising, unusually coherent product hypothesis** with good prototype coverage of its hardest decisions. Lead with researcher competence — *“Get from a messy survey file to an answer you can explain and revise”* — and avoid “instant insights” or “replace the researcher.”

Observe six to eight recent projects, not opinions about AI.

Split participants between agency research leads, data/operations staff, and client-side recipients. For each, ask for a real questionnaire or codebook, received data, analysis file, delivered deck, and one revision or client query — redacted where needed.

Reconstruct what happened, then have the researcher perform four tasks in both their current stack and the relevant prototype:

TASK	WHAT TO OBSERVE
Explain a disputed percentage	Files opened, people contacted, time to find the exact base, and whether the explanation is correct.
Investigate a quality exclusion or weight change	Whether they inspect effects before applying a rule; what they record about the decision. (Pew's design is a ready-made template.)
Revise a delivered headline	Which numbers, prose, charts, and caveats they remember to update — and which they miss.
Bring in the next tracker wave	How they detect changes in wording, routing, codes, sample source, and comparability. Include one deliberately incompatible change.

Record

- Rework and wrong assumptions caught
- Handoffs and people contacted
- Time spent checking vs reasoning
- Confidence explaining the result, and whether that confidence was warranted
- False assurances and unsupported suggestions from the tool

Don't rely on

- Task completion alone
- Preference for a screen
- General attitudes to AI — six surveys already cover these
- Comparison against a weak baseline; include Displayr/Q or the participant's own stack

WHAT WOULD PROVE THE HYPOTHESIS WRONG

If researchers using the prototype make as many consequential corrections, miss as many stale claims after a change, or take longer to reach a defensible answer than in their current stack, the position fails — regardless of how much they like the interface. If the added definition work slows common tasks for experienced Q/Displayr users without catching more errors, narrow to a preparation-and-review integration instead.

The research question is now sharp: *can one researcher carry a defensible answer through a change with less reconstruction and less risk than they can today?* If yes, in real projects, that is a compelling researcher-oriented wedge for agencies and their clients alike.

How this was researched

This report extends an initial desk review (supplied by the product owner) and Velocity’s research note *docs/research_quantitative_researcher_work_2026.md*. New research was conducted on 26 September 2026 using web search. Direct page fetches to most publishers (Pew, Greenbook, Displayr, arXiv, Hacker News, Reddit, LinkedIn) were blocked by this environment’s network policy, so figures and quotations were taken from search-indexed excerpts and summaries of the named sources. Items not independently re-verified in this pass are marked below. **Before any external use, check each quotation and figure against the original.** No first-hand interviews, observed sessions, or competitor hands-on tests were performed; nothing here measures Velocity’s effect on researchers.

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Not re-verified in this pass: the MRS 2022 supply-side talent study; ESOMAR's \$56bn/\$62bn/\$35bn category split; the ClientSight sample size; GRIT's 101–500-staff supplier analysis. These are carried from the originating memo and Velocity's research note.